

Two Islands, Two Authors named Beni, Two Stories: A Structural Comparison of Ben Blushi's Two Versions of *Të jetosh në ishull* and the Fan Fiction of Ben K. Blushi

Author(s): Dhimiter Mbrothi, MCT

Abstract: This essay compares two texts that share the title *Të jetosh në ishull*: Ben Blushi's historical-metaphorical novel and a five-chapter piece of fan fiction attributed to Ben K. Blushi. It argues that the two works construct radically different islands. In the novel, the island is a historical, national, and religious space through which collective identity is examined; in the fan fiction, it is a psychic landscape shaped by narcissism, desire, violence, and the fear of disappearance. Through close attention to deification, eroticism, cosmic imagery, and the comic reduction of metaphysical grandeur to bodily dependence, the essay reads the second text as a distorted intertextual commentary on the first. The comparison ultimately reveals two literary projects: one concerned with the fate of a nation and the other with the fragile, ridiculous, and bodily limits of the individual.

Keywords: Albanian literature, Ben Blushi, new Albanian literature, modern literature

1 Introduction

One might speak of a small conspiracy among Albanian writers who, out of playfulness or envy, attempt to rewrite Ben Blushi's prose. Perhaps they want to attack him, or simply to hitch themselves to his success. But how can anyone compete with a writer who has the resources, the networks, and the books needed to command public attention? Certainly not by rewriting his stories.

Such writers would do better to tell stories of their own. This may be where Ben K. Blushi has found a niche: a small corner beyond the reach of mass-media campaigns and the fine-grained segmentation of Albania's limited reading public. The audience may number only a few, perhaps a handful, but it exists—and it is a niche worth believing in. Ben K. Blushi appears to be writing for precisely that audience.

Writing the same story twice is always a tedious undertaking, even when that undertaking displays all the qualities associated with Ben Blushi: coherence, persistence, and an unwavering commitment to the political mission of Westernization. What the Iranian writer Jalal Al-e Ahmad dismissively calls *Gharbzadegi*—a Western intoxication, or a confusion produced by the West and its technological toys—Ben Blushi turns into an intellectual virtue and a desirable habit of mind.

Ben Blushi's novel *Të jetosh në ishull* has already established itself in Albanian literary space as a text concerned with history, religion, and collective identity. These themes appear to be especially dear to the author: in each book or interview, he returns to them, sometimes changing little more than the protagonists' positions and physical descriptions.

When another version is placed alongside this book—a piece of fan fiction written by an admirer under the name *Ben K. Blushi* and bearing the same title—an intertextual game immediately emerges: a distorting mirror, a silent commentary, a novel within a novel.

This essay compares these two narrative “islands”: Ben Blushi’s well-known novel, which engages with grand themes, and the five-chapter fan-fiction cycle about Mihali, who experiences the island as a psychic condition. The purpose is not to decide which work is better, or to compare the original with the product of a devotee of Blushian literature. Rather, the analysis brings into view the two distinct literary projects concealed behind the same title: a historical-metaphorical novel about a confused and conflicted collective “we,” and a radically introspective prose poem about a fractured “I.”

2 The Historical Island and the Psychic Island

In Ben Blushi’s novel, the island is first and foremost a historical and metaphorical category. It is connected to particular historical periods, political contexts, and figures belonging to national memory. The text addresses historiography, religion, and myth. Its central question, even when posed through a fictional plot, is: “Who are we as a collective? What have we done with the past, how do we project the future, and how do we confront the idea of eternity?”

For example, Blushi takes up themes with political consequences arising from Albania’s position in the international arena and from the struggle against Islamization or Islamic doctrine. This is visible in his treatment of Sali Berisha (Sali Benishi in the novel), Albania’s former president, and Hafiz Sabri, chairman of Albania’s Muslim Community (represented in the novel simply as the imam), whom a group of journalists, including Mero Baze, accused of seeking to Islamize the country.

Sali Benishi sat down and turned toward the imam. All the men in the room did the same. The imam let his prayer beads fall to the floor, between his bare feet, and addressed Sali Benishi: Welcome, brother in my suffering! Thanks to you and to God, I am in this holy city, which God has decided to give to Muslims. God is up there, waiting for Muslims to accept the gift He has given them.

In Ben K. Blushi’s fan-fictional version, the island is essentially a psychic space. Its themes are smaller, consisting largely of suggestive discoveries and experiments of a sexual nature. The protagonist has no precise historical coordinates: the sea, the forest, shadowy figures, trees, stones, lionesses, and indigenous tribes appear as projections of an ego exhausted by itself. The five chapters construct an inner map, not a geographical one. The question is no longer “Who are we?” but “What am I when I have no reason left to live beyond my physical needs?”

In chapters 1–3, Mihali, the protagonist, pursues “enemies/lovers” who are largely internal projections. The author himself becomes an object of projection: a tree-man, a man made of stone, a hypersexual creature in the form of a lioness-seal, or an upside-down god. The game thus reverses direction and deepens the question of identity: what happens when others invent you?

We therefore have two kinds of *islands* engaging the mind of the Albanian intellectual:

- in Blushi: island-history, island-nation, island-religion. The self is investigated through these grand themes, which can both conceal the self behind grand ideas and promise the individual's soul a form of immortality in another faith;
- in the fictional version: island-consciousness, island-narcissism, island-existential crisis. The result is the discovery of the self as a physical and mortal being.

3 Deification, Narcissism, and Violence

One of the clearest points of contact between the two projects is their treatment of divinity and violence. Ben Blushi's novel plays with divinity, religion, and mythologized national figures in order to problematize the ways collective cults are built and destroyed. Deification is always suspect: the elevation of one figure often proceeds alongside the suppression of others.

In Ben K. Blushi's fan-fictional novella, this logic becomes a small but brutal experiment, particularly in chapter IV ("Easter Island").

Mihali awakens on an island where the indigenous people raise giant statues bearing his face, carve his name into mountains, stones, and trees, and sacrifice animals and people "in his name." At first he remains silent and enjoys the adoration; later he realizes that his silence is an act of consent. The climax comes when the tribe, in the name of that same worship, destroys the forests, eliminates the animals, descends into civil war, and disappears.

The Easter Island/statue-cult motif connects neatly to Mihali's narcissism (his pleasure at being worshipped), his guilt (the sacrifices and violence committed in his name), and ecological destruction (every tree is cut down, the animals disappear, and the community destroys itself). This gives the novella a political and ecological dimension. In the end, everything is destroyed, and he is left alone among his own stone faces. It is a powerful image of the loneliness, vanity, and emptiness of the "glory" the protagonist pursued at any cost.

This scene is a small parable of the mechanism underlying every act of deification:

1. the need for a name onto which fears and desires can be projected;
2. the construction of a ritual system in that name;
3. the justification of violence in service of that system;
4. ecological and ethical devastation;
5. the remains of a "god" without believers, surrounded by ruins bearing his name.

In this sense, the fictional version is a miniature that shifts the problem from the national level, as in the work of the real Blushi, to the ego of an individual. Instead of a nation projecting its history onto a hero, we have a

man who silently accepts being elevated above others and is ultimately left alone with his guilt.

4 Eroticism: Nature, Stone, Animal, Universe

Another important difference lies in the treatment of eroticism. At least in its critical reception, Ben Blushi's novel intertwines human love with religious and ethical tensions, but it does not turn nature into a direct sexual partner.

In Ben K. Blushi, Mihali's entire journey consists of a series of "loves" that are impossible, increasingly ambiguous, and increasingly perverse. Even the vulgar ones can be interpreted as stages of personal development or moments of reflection on the part of the real author, Ben Blushi:

- chapter 1: the homoerotic encounter with the man of the forest, which ends in an ecological love affair with a tree (perhaps a form of autoeroticism with his own shadow)—this suggests Ben Blushi's relationship with himself and his desire to hear his own echo in public;
- chapter 2: the homoerotic encounter with the stone man, which ends in a paleontological love affair with a rock (perhaps even a dinosaur or mammoth fossil, turning sexual penetration into something transhistorical)—this symbolizes Ben Blushi's enduring obsession with the Turks and Islam;
- chapter 3: the erotic encounter with a hybrid mythological creature—part lioness, part siren, part seal—in which Mihali learns to love without categories (neither human nor animal nor mere symbol) and makes love inside another creature's anus (a "breathing tunnel")—all of this symbolizes Ben Blushi's autoerotic confusion as author, politician, and journalist;
- chapter 4: the "love" of the tribe that worships him as a god and destroys everything in his name, while the god's heads bore into the island until it dies—an image of Ben Blushi's desire to remain at the center of attention through provocative yet simultaneously stale and sterile theses;
- chapter 5: the cosmic attraction of the stars to the protagonist, the universe's cosmo-erotic invitation to merge with "millions of souls," and the joining of an interstellar orgy—a symbol of Ben Blushi's estrangement from religion and his inability to understand his place in the universe.

At every stage, eroticism is tied to a crisis of identity: the protagonist does not know with whom he has actually made love. With nature? With his own projections? With the people who worship him? With the idea of eternity itself? Everything is an attempt to dissolve into the other and avoid confronting himself as a mortal body.

This leads to the final scene, which is profoundly anti-romantic and realist: the nurse tells him, "Turn on your side so I can change your underwear." At that moment, all the metaphysical eroticism is re-scaled. The man descends from his role as one who embraces trees, stones, mythological animals, and

the universe, and becomes once again a mortal body whose backside someone must clean—someone named Beni.

5 The Cosmic and the Comic

In Blushi, the cosmic dimension of divinity and history appears as a question: how are the human being, the nation, God, and eternity connected? Even when religion or mythology is criticized, the weight of these categories is acknowledged.

In the fan-fictional version, the final chapter takes this question to an extreme: Mihali feels the call of the stars, while the universe “asks for his soul” so that it can join billions of others. For a moment he surrenders to the idea of merging, of losing the self in an ocean of souls. Then he stops and “steals” his soul back from the universe so as not to disappear as a name, a history, or a distinct being.

This moment is a direct commentary on delusions of grandeur: a person wants, at the same time, to be part of something boundless *and* to remain distinct, recognizable, and called “Beni.” The fear of final disappearance drives him to reject even cosmic consolation.

The comic climax—the nurse and the soiled underwear—functions as an *anti-deus ex machina*. Instead of a divine resolution that restores cosmic order, the text offers a banal bodily scene. This scene demolishes every illusion of grandeur: god, great writer, cosmic spirit. It anchors the subject in an indisputable reality: being a mortal body that suffers, soils itself, and needs another person’s care. The scene produces laughter and, at the same time, a measure of pity: this ridiculous scene of dependence is precisely what all human beings share.

Compared with the serious horizon of Ben Blushi’s novel, this is a much more cynical but also more liberating move: what one work presents as the fate of a nation is here held hostage by the fate shared by all bodies in a hospital bed.

6 Two Literary Projects

The comparison of these two texts reveals two very different literary projects, despite their shared title:

1. **Ben Blushi’s project:** A historical-metaphorical novel that illuminates gaps in history and problematizes religion, identity, and the relationship to myth. The island figures historical isolation: a nation seeking to construct itself between empires and ideologies.
2. **Ben K. Blushi’s project:** An introspective novella with a lyrical structure that illuminates the gaps of ego, desire, narcissism, and the fear of extinction. The island figures psychic isolation: a man inventing enemies, lovers, gods, and universes simply to avoid the final scene—bodily and moral dependence.

In this sense, the “novella” can be read as a multifaceted *critical commentary*:

- on the illusions of the writer who wishes to speak about the “nation” while bypassing (or concealing) the shame of his own body and his toxic desires for fame, money, and power;
- on religious and political illusions, shared by followers and those they pursue, who use another person’s name as a pretext for physical or structural violence, or to cleanse a politically tainted image or revenues derived from corruption;
- on the cosmic illusion that promises the loss of the self without taking an individual’s concrete fears into account.

7 Conclusion

Both “islands” are, in a sense, laboratories. In Ben Blushi, the laboratory is history: what happens when a people reads itself as chosen, victimized, and heir to a lost heroism? In Ben K. Blushi, the laboratory is a body and a mind: what happens when an individual refuses to accept his limitations and flies from one illusion to the next?

In the end, the historical novel remains open to collective debate, while the introspective novella closes in a hospital room, with a man who sees himself for the first time not as a metaphysical project but as an ordinary being in need of help and other people. This is perhaps where the two texts meet: each, in its own way, attempts to break the illusions of grandeur and direct attention toward what is most difficult to accept—human vulnerability, whether understood collectively or individually.